Farther south, near the Gujarat–Rajasthan border, the Aravallis briefly lay claim to being mountains rather than mere hills. The Guru Shikhar peak at Mount Abu rises to 1722 metres above sea level. This is a sacred place of temples and legends. The Rajput warrior clans claim that their ancestors arose from a great sacrificial fire on this mountain. Not far from Abu is the beautiful lake-city of Udaipur. This was once the capital of the kingdom of Mewar, which bravely fought medieval invaders against impossible odds. The hills and valleys still ring with ballads of how Rana Pratap and his army of Bhil tribesmen refused to surrender to the Mughals. Long before all these events, however, the Aravallis witnessed a major shift in the evolution of life on this planet.

Fossil records suggest that around 530 million years ago, there was a sudden appearance of a large number of complex organisms. This is called the Cambrian Explosion although it still took millions of years. Over the next 70-80 million years, we see an astonishing array of life forms evolve. Meanwhile, the continental land masses began to reassemble and, around 270 million years ago, they fused into a new supercontinent called Pangea.[4] It is now thought that this cyclical assembling and breaking up of supercontinents has always been a part of the geological history of the earth.

A map of Pangea would show the Indian craton wedged between Africa, Madagascar, Antarctica and Australia (see map). It was on Pangea that the dinosaurs appeared 230 million years ago. However, the earth remained restless and Pangea began to break up around 175 million years ago during the Jurassic era. It first split into a northern continent called Laurasia (consisting of North America, Europe and Asia) and a southern continent called Gondwana (Africa, South America, Antarctica, Australia and India). Note that the name Gondwana is itself derived from the Gond tribe of central India.

We now see a sequence of rifts that separate India from its neighbours. First, India and Madagascar separated from Africa around 158 million years ago and then, 130 million years ago, they separated from Antarctica.